Building the Urban Video Archive: A Community-Driven and Technologically Adaptive Approach to Emancipatory Archiving

Nassiri, Hamidreza
hamidreza.nassiri@gmail.com
Independent Scholar, United States of America

Geuder, Jacob
jacob.geuder@googlemail.com
University of Neuchâtel, Switzerland

In partnership with Brazilian media activists, we have developed the Urban Video Archive (UVA), a digital repository of video activism in Rio de Janeiro. The videos in this archive capture a spectrum of events and narratives, ranging from the documentation of protests and instances of state violence to public interviews and speeches. The archive chronicles the urban struggles of marginalized communities, including indigenous people, Afro-descendants, and women, from 2013 to 2023.

This poster will focus on the archive's development, highlighting the practices and challenges of co-creation and community archiving. Contributing to the "archival turn" towards emancipatory and community-centered approaches (Webb 2018; Cook 2013), UVA was born from the need of Brazilian media activists for a safe and accessible archive space, free from the influence of institutions and corporate social media regulations.

UVA's infrastructure was built in co-creation with a video activist collective from Rio de Janeiro (Mídia Independente Coletiva), involving the selection, interpretation, organization, and presentation of the records. UVA is not merely a repository but a navigable resource, featuring an interactive map that illustrates the struggles' geographic dimension. We designed the database structure to support multiple, interconnected modes of exploration, thereby enabling more contextual and network-based analysis. The goal was to create a less sensationalist approach than those practiced by social media platforms (Neumayer / Struthers 2018; Poell / van Dijck 2015), which aim to maximize engagement and often produce spectacles of violence. This was the vision of the independent media activists on the ground, who often emphasized the necessity to focus not only on individual events containing "spectacular" violence but also on the underlying systemic and racialized structures of violence.

Journalist and core figure of Rio de Janeiro's media activist movement, Carlos Augusto Lima França, provided a first categorization and localization of all videos in the collection in January 2022. In 2023, all videos within the collection were further tagged and organized in collaboration with another member of the Mídia Independente Coletiva, Alex Soares. This extensive process of co-creating the archival structure allows users three different forms of navigation: 1) a geographical search via mapping; 2) a systematic search via filters; and 3) an intuitive and networked discovery through integrated hashtags. (Figures 1 to 3)

The primary feature is an interactive map that provides a spatial representation of events. By situating occurrences within their geographic contexts, this tool is especially valuable for examining struggles over urban rights—such as the right to the city and housing rights. By spatializing human rights violations, the map challenges the presumed neutrality of both urban spaces and cartographic practices (Sachs Olsen 2016: 512; Katz 2023). It also yields deeper insights into the geographical distribution and patterns of these events.

The archive's search functionality is enhanced by filters and hashtags, co-designed with activists, to connect videos through common themes and subjects. This arrangement helps users observe the underlying interconnectedness of the issues represented. The resulting networked structure offers a more nuanced context for these materials, countering the often sensationalized and fragmented nature of video activism on social media.

In the poster, we will present not only the co-creation process and its logistics but also the technical aspects of building this archive, detailing the tools, methods, and codes employed. We relied exclusively on open-access software, taking into account concerns such as politically biased cartographies and the need for flexibility. The result is a highly adaptable infrastructure that supports the creation and scaling of similar archives. By sharing this knowledge, we contribute to making such archives more accessible to communities worldwide.

Finally, in the poster, we will briefly lay out the accessibility challenges confronting this and similar community-driven archives, examining both production-level and user-level accessibility concerns and their influence on shaping narratives. These financial, logistical, technological, and po-

litical challenges highlight the tensions between community-driven and institutional approaches to archiving, revealing how grassroots efforts frequently clash with the entrenched power structures and established practices of larger institutions (see Poole 2020; Fischer et al. 2019; Kilberg 2024). Additionally, to counter the threat of digital obsolescence, which endangers the long-term survival of marginalized narratives, we use detailed spreadsheets and video transcripts as partial safeguards.

The archive is accessible via https://urbanvideoarchive.vercel.app/ . Our ongoing work involves making all materials—including video transcripts—available in both English and Portuguese; ensuring that the video repository is hosted on a secure server with ownership rights retained by the video creators; and refining our methods and tools to enhance the archive's visibility and resilience against digital obsolescence.

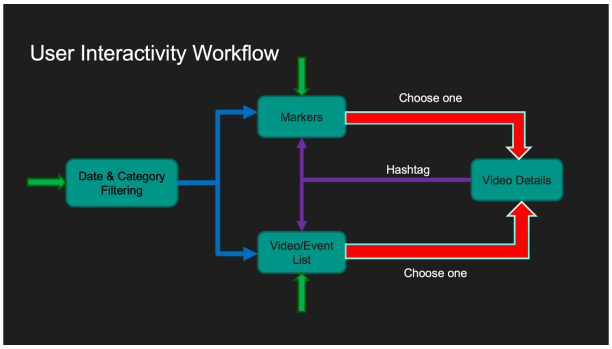

Figure 1. Screenshot of the Urban Video Archive interface. Users can refine searches using date and category filters at the top. Search results appear as interactive map markers and a corresponding video list on the right.

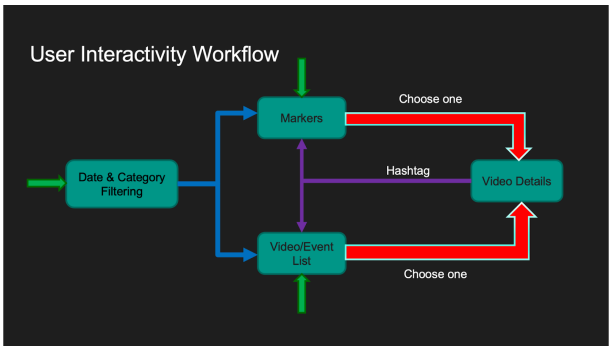

Figure 2. Clicking a map marker or a video list item zooms the map to the selected location and displays video details on the right. Clickable hashtags in the details panel initiate a refined search based on the selected tag.

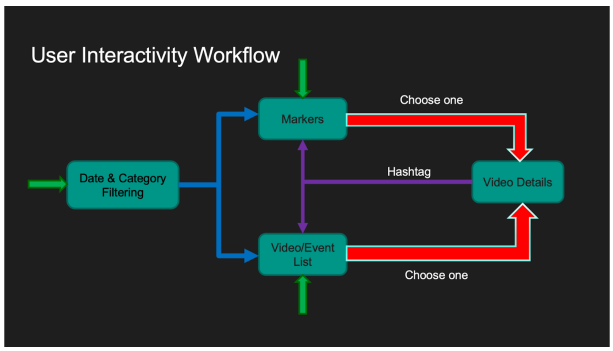

Figure 3. User Interactivity Workflow in the Urban Video Archive. Green arrows (left, top, and bottom) indicate user interaction points that trigger system responses. Other arrows represent internal system processes that update the interface accordingly.

Bibliography

Cook, Terry (2013): "Evidence, Memory, Identity, and Community: Four Shifting Archival Paradigms", in: Archival Science 13: 95–120. DOI: 10.1007/s10502-012-9180-7.

Fischer, Beth / Jacobs, Hannah / Cahoon, Claire / Huffman, Noah (2019): "Budgets & Funding for Archival Projects", in: Visualizing Objects, Places, and Spaces: A Digital Project Handbook . PubPub. DOI: 10.21428/51bee781.ce977d63.

Katz, Catherine Grace (2023): "One Map to Rule Them All: Google Maps and Quasi-Sovereign Power in International Legal Disputes", in: Hastings Science & Technology Law Journal 14: 67–122 < https://repository.uchastings.edu/hastings_science_technology_law_journal/vol14/iss1/4 > [29.04.2025].

Kilberg, Rebecca (2024): "The Cost of a Digital Archive", in: Library Innovation Lab (blog), February 8 < https://lil.law.harvard.edu/blog/2024/02/08/the-cost-of-a-digital-archive/ > [29.04.2025].

Neumayer, Christina / Struthers, David M. (2018): "Social Media As Activist Archives", in: Mortensen, Mette / Neumayer, Christina / Poell, Thomas (eds.): Social Media Materialities and Protest: Critical Reflections . London / New York: Routledge.

Poell, Thomas / van Dijck, José (2015): "Social Media and Activist Communication", in: Atton, Chris (ed.): The Routledge Companion to Alterna-

tive and Community Media . London: Routledge 527–537.

Poole, Alex H. (2020): “The Information Work of Community Archives: A Systematic Literature Review”, in: Journal of Documentation 76, 3: 657–687. DOI: 10.1108/JD-07-2019-0140.

Sachs Olsen, Cecilie (2016): “ Performing Urban Archives – A Starting Point for Exploration”, in: Cultural Geographies 23, 3: 511–515. DOI: 10.1177/1474474016638048.

Webb, Sharon (2018): “‘Digital Archives in Communities – Practice and Preservation’: A Summary (or at least an attempt)”, in: Digital Preservation Coalition (blog) < https://www.dpconline.org/blog/digital-archives-in-communities > [29.04.2025].